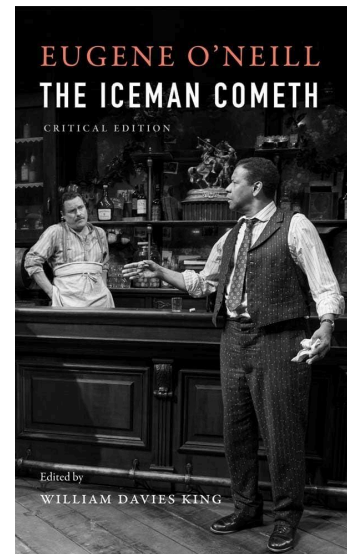
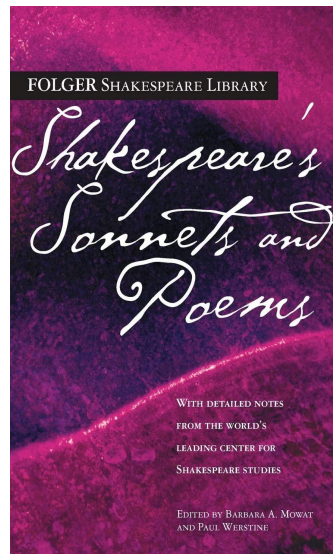
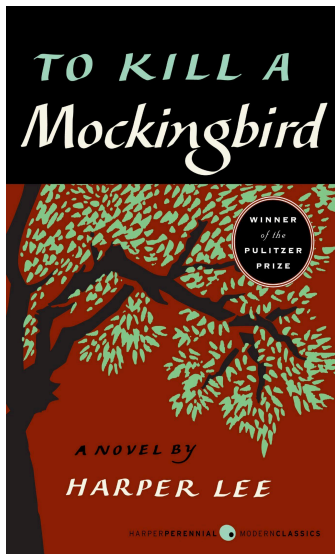




UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Literary Criticism

District • 2026



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District • 2026

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History

30 items (1 point each)

1. An intensified form of the revenge tragedy made popular on the Elizabethan stage by Thomas Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* and then emulated in William Shakespeare's *Hamlet* is (the)
A) requiem.
B) *Sturm und Drang*.
C) theatrum mundi.
D) tragedy of blood.
E) turpiloquium.
2. The winged horse of Grecian fable said to have sprung from Medusa's body at her death that is associated with the inspiration of poetry is
A) Bucephalus.
B) Gringolet.
C) Pegasus.
D) Phaeton.
E) Xanthus.
3. **Not** one of the duple feet in quantitative or accentual-syllabic verse is
A) anapest.
B) iamb.
C) pyrrhic.
D) spondee.
E) trochee.
4. The recipient of the 1981 Pulitzer Prize for Drama, many of whose screenplays and plays, including the Pulitzer-winning *Crimes of the Heart*, have been made into movies, is
A) Mary Chase.
B) Beth Henley.
C) Marsha Norman.
D) Suzan-Lori Parks.
E) Wendy Wasserstein.
5. The term that is applied to the authorized or accepted list of books belonging, for example, in the Christian Bible, or accepted as attributable to a particular author, or as the body of recognized representative works of a particular group, is
A) canon.
B) cento.
C) chrestomathy.
D) omnibus.
E) pastiche.
6. The term that, from the very late nineteenth century through the twenty-first, denotes the various newspapers and magazines specializing in scandal and sensation is
A) affective fallacy.
B) intentional fallacy.
C) metafiction.
D) pathetic fallacy.
E) yellow journalism.
7. **Not** one of the divisions comprising one and one-half centuries of cultural and artistic energy known as the English Renaissance (1500-1660) is the
A) Caroline Age.
B) Commonwealth Interregnum.
C) Edwardian Age.
D) Elizabethan Age.
E) Jacobean Age.
8. The eighteenth-century British author of six novels of sensibility including *Pride and Prejudice* and *Emma* is
A) Jane Austen.
B) Charlotte Brontë.
C) Emily Brontë.
D) Anne Radcliffe.
E) Charlotte Smith.
9. The critical approach based on psychological speculations and discoveries that argues the influence of the unconscious and that has offered a new light on character relationships in literary works is
A) absolutist criticism.
B) feminist criticism.
C) Freudian criticism.
D) historical criticism.
E) Marxist criticism.
10. The process by which an unhealthy emotional state produced by an imbalance of feelings is corrected and emotional health is restored, especially in terms of an audience's response to the fate of a tragic hero, is known as
A) catharsis.
B) dramatic irony.
C) hubris.
D) mixed figures.
E) peripety.

11. As understood in the context of literary expression, the intelligible use of a foreign language that a character or a speaker does not know is called
 - A) amphigory.
 - B) double entendre.
 - C) glossolalia.
 - D) heteroglossia.
 - E) xenoglossia.
12. The recently deceased (2020) Irish-British novelist known mainly for his espionage novels, several of which have been adapted into acclaimed films and television series, as well as for his novel *The Naïve and Sentimental Lover*, whose title literally points to its genre, is
 - A) Arthur Conan Doyle.
 - B) Ian Fleming.
 - C) John Fowles.
 - D) Graham Greene.
 - E) John le Carré.
13. The type, often literary, that as a model of the mysteriously brooding, bitter, vaguely northern loner, sexually polymorphous, reckless and doomed, and always dangerous, is known as
 - A) Acmeism.
 - B) Byronism.
 - C) Gongorism.
 - D) Marinism.
 - E) Orphism.
14. **Not** a term that describes either a character **or** a form of expression that reflects some degree of excess is
 - A) alazon.
 - B) braggadocio.
 - C) eiron.
 - D) gasconade.
 - E) rodomontade.
15. In its figurative sense, the special usage of a word or words, often without the conscious knowledge of the author or reader, in which there is a change in the word's or words' basic meanings is
 - A) denotation.
 - B) diction.
 - C) digression.
 - D) imagery.
 - E) plain style.
16. The nineteenth-century English Church reform movement led by John Henry Newman, and attracting the attention of various literary men and women, is
 - A) the Free Verse Movement.
 - B) The Movement.
 - C) the Oxford Movement.
 - D) the Pre-Raphaelite Movement.
 - E) the Spoken Word Movement.
17. The movement in literary, graphic, and cinematic art developed in early-twentieth century France by André Breton and reaching the United States after World War II that emphasizes the expression of the imagination as realized in dreams and presented without conscious control is
 - A) aestheticism.
 - B) cubism.
 - C) impressionism.
 - D) minimalism.
 - E) surrealism.
18. The author of the short story collections *Everything That Rises Must Converge*, *"A Good Man Is Hard to Find" and Other Stories*, and the novels *Wise Blood* and *The Violent Bear It Away* is the Southern writer
 - A) Zora Neale Hurston.
 - B) Jhumpa Lahiri.
 - C) Carson McCullers.
 - D) Flannery O'Connor.
 - E) Katherine Anne Porter.
19. The recipient of the 1967 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for her collection *Live or Die*, which addresses her dealing with her bipolar disorder is
 - A) Rita Dove.
 - B) Louise Glück.
 - C) Mary Oliver.
 - D) Anne Sexton.
 - E) Mayra Zaturenska.
20. A cheaply produced paperbound novel or novelette of mystery, adventure, or violence popular during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries in England is called a
 - A) dime novel.
 - B) gothic novel.
 - C) penny dreadful.
 - D) potboiler.
 - E) pulp magazine.

21. The modern movement in politics, economics, and literature, the most apparent characteristics being brevity, economy, and modesty, is
 - A) æstheticism.
 - B) existentialism.
 - C) hedonism.
 - D) minimalism.
 - E) relativism.
22. The loosely connected group of mid-nineteenth-century British Victorian poets whose verse reflects contemporary discontent and unrest and whose intensely emotional style is marked by jerkiness and strained emphasis is the
 - A) Cockney School.
 - B) Lake School.
 - C) Martian School.
 - D) Satanic School.
 - E) Spasmodic School.
23. An elaborated comparison differing from other comparisons in being more involved and ornate in an arguably conscious imitation of the Homeric manner is known as a(n)
 - A) epic simile.
 - B) mixed metaphor.
 - C) motif.
 - D) pleonasm.
 - E) syllepsis.
24. The Norwegian novelist and playwright whose works have been translated into over fifty languages and who was awarded the 2023 Nobel Prize in Literature "for his innovative plays and prose which give voice to the unsayable" is
 - A) Jon Olav Fosse.
 - B) Knut Hamsun.
 - C) Carl Gustaf Verner von Heidenstam.
 - D) Johannes V. Jensen.
 - E) Harry Edmund Martinson.
25. **Not** a term for an author looking for some degree of anonymity regarding the authorship of a literary work is
 - A) allonym.
 - B) implied author.
 - C) *nom de plume*.
 - D) pen name.
 - E) putative author.
26. The term that usually refers to the English- and Latin-language pentameter poetic line having the pattern adjective-noun-adjective-noun is
 - A) boustrophedonic line.
 - B) end-stopped line.
 - C) golden line.
 - D) pyramidal line.
 - E) rhopalic line.
27. The twentieth-century British novelist who wrote *The Collector* (a novel that "probably [garnered] the highest price that had hitherto been paid for a first novel"), *The Magus*, *The French Lieutenant's Woman*, *The Ebony Tower*, *A Maggot*, and *Daniel Martin* is
 - A) John Fowles.
 - B) John le Carré.
 - C) W. Somerset Maugham.
 - D) George Orwell.
 - E) H. G. Wells.
28. The complex transumption of figures of speech as is found in "Stone the crows by all means, but let the birds of paradise get on with the business of being gorgeous" is known as
 - A) hypallage.
 - B) metalepsis.
 - C) metonymy.
 - D) reification.
 - E) synecdoche.
29. The philosophy of life that maintains that pleasure is the chief good of human beings, a doctrine that takes two forms: the source of happiness is through the gratification of the sensual instincts or, simply, the avoidance (the absence) of pain is
 - A) æstheticism.
 - B) cynicism.
 - C) fatalism.
 - D) hedonism.
 - E) meliorism.
30. The recipient of the 1981 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his highly acclaimed and allusively titled *A Confederacy of Dunces* is
 - A) Saul Bellow.
 - B) John Cheever.
 - C) Norman Mailer.
 - D) John Kennedy Toole.
 - E) John Updike.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List

20 items (2 points each)

Items 31-35 are associated with Eugene O'Neill's *The Iceman Cometh*.

Items 36-42 are associated with Harper Lee's *To Kill a Mockingbird*.

Items 43-50 are associated with William Shakespeare's sonnets.

-
31. In Eugene O'Neill's *The Iceman Cometh*, the response to Rocky's comment on his interlocuter's longevity under duress, "Yes, it's my bad luck to be cursed with an iron constitution," is spoken by
- A) Don.
 - B) Harry.
 - C) Hickey
 - D) Larry.
 - E) Willie.
32. The explanation "I was knocked off my base by that business on the Coast, and since then it's been no fun dodging around the country, thinking every guy you see might be a [detective]" is offered to Larry by
- A) Chuck.
 - B) Harry.
 - C) Hickey.
 - D) Hugo.
 - E) Parritt.
33. "Tell de gang I'll be along in a minute. I'm just finishin' figurin' out de best way to save dem and bring dem peace" is Cora's reporting the words of
- A) James Cameron.
 - B) Theodore Hickman.
 - C) Harry Hope.
 - D) Don Parrit.
 - E) Larry Slade.
34. The sharp critique "You were all so busy drinking of the words of wisdom from the Old Wise Guy here, you couldn't hear anything else" refers to
- A) Hickey.
 - B) Jimmy.
 - C) Joe.
 - D) Larry.
 - E) Willie.
35. The term "bug house," used over and over in conversations as either a noun or an adjective, means
- A) crazy.
 - B) ill-advised.
 - C) incautious.
 - D) infested.
 - E) surveilled.
36. In Harper Lee's *To Kill a Mockingbird*, "one of the few men of science who never terrified [Scout], probably because he never behaved like a doctor [and would give them] an estimation of how much it would hurt," was
- A) Mr. Cunningham.
 - B) Mr. Gilmer.
 - C) Uncle Jack.
 - D) Reverend Sykes.
 - E) Judge Taylor.
37. "He's in my grade, and he does right well. He's a good boy, a real nice boy. We brought him home for dinner one time. Maybe he told you about me; I beat him up one time but he was real nice about it. Tell him hey for me, won't you?" Scout is speaking to
- A) Mr. Avery.
 - B) Mr. Cunningham.
 - C) Mr. Gilmer.
 - D) Mr. Raymond.
 - E) Mr. Underwood.
38. "Jem was the product of their first year of marriage; four years later I was born, and two years later our mother died" from (a/n)
- A) automobile accident.
 - B) cancer.
 - C) heart attack.
 - D) pneumonia.
 - E) tuberculosis.
39. "I simply want to tell you that there are some men in this world who were born to do our unpleasant jobs for us. Your father's one of them" is counsel given by
- A) Miss Atkinson.
 - B) Miss Crawford.
 - C) Mrs. Dubose.
 - D) Mrs. Merriweather.
 - E) Mrs. Robinson.
40. The forensic evidence—the circumstantial evidence, as Finch frames it—upon which, in part, his defense relies is
- A) Mayella's need for kindling.
 - B) Robinson's ambidextrousness.
 - C) Robinson's left-handedness.
 - D) Robinson's marital status.
 - E) Robinson's right-handedness.

41. "I think I'm beginning to understand something. I think I'm beginning to understand why Boo Radley's stayed shut up in the house all this time . . . it's because he wants to stay inside" is
- A) Atticus's epiphany.
 - B) Calpurnia's epiphany.
 - C) Dill's epiphany.
 - D) Jem's epiphany.
 - E) Scout's epiphany.
42. "There's no difference between one man who's going to convict and another man who's going to convict, is there? There's a faint difference between a man who's going to convict and a man who's a little disturbed in his mind, isn't there? He was the only uncertainty on the whole list" is Finch's explanation regarding his decision not to
- A) convict the indicted.
 - B) defend the defendant.
 - C) judge the convicted.
 - D) prosecute the guilty.
 - E) strike a potential juror.

Items 43-50 refer to William Shakespeare's

[Devouring time, blunt thou the lion's paws]

Devouring time, blunt thou the lion's paws
 And make the earth devour her own sweet brood,
 Pluck the keen teeth from the fierce tiger's jaws
 And burn the long-liv'd phoenix in her blood, 4
 Make glad and sorry seasons as thou fleet'st,
 And do what e'er thou wilt, swift-footed time,
 To the wide world and all her fading sweets:
 But I forbid thee one most heinous crime, 8
 O carve not with thy hours my love's fair brow,
 Nor draw no lines there with thine antique pen,
 Him in thy course untainted do allow
 For beauty's pattern to succeeding men. 12
 Yet do thy worst, old time, despite thy wrong,
 My love shall in my verse ever live young.

43. In Shakespeare's Sonnet 19 "[Devouring time, blunt thou the lion's paws]," the speaker's commanding "devouring time" to make, to pluck, to burn, and then forbidding the concept "old time" to carve or to draw lines constitute a(n)
- A) apostrophe.
 - B) aside.
 - C) harangue.
 - D) invocation.
 - E) soliloquy.
44. The speaker's addressing the concept *time* (throughout the sonnet's litany of imperatives), as well as his referencing the concept *beauty* (line 12) as if they are physical objects, are both instances of
- A) anthropomorphism.
 - B) apostrophe.
 - C) kenosis.
 - D) reification.
 - E) zoomorphism.
45. The essential repetition in close proximity of line 1's *devouring* and its root *devour* (line 2) constitutes
- A) anaphora.
 - B) epanalepsis.
 - C) pleonasm.
 - D) polyptoton.
 - E) polysyndeton.
46. The speaker's referencing, in line 9, his "love's fair brow," meaning, of course, the fullness of the face is
- A) chiasmus.
 - B) hyperbole.
 - C) litotes.
 - D) synæsthesia.
 - E) synecdoche.
47. The Elizabethan penchant for the naming-descriptor "swift-footed time" shows an appreciation for the
- A) affective fallacy.
 - B) diminished metaphor.
 - C) Homeric epithet.
 - D) Homeric simile.
 - E) pathetic fallacy.
48. The placement of sentence elements out of order to accommodate meter and rhyme as found in line 11 is
- A) accentualism.
 - B) inversion.
 - C) metathesis.
 - D) ornamentalism.
 - E) reversal.
49. The internal rhyme occurring in line 3's "keen teeth" is known as
- A) assonance.
 - B) consonance.
 - C) dissonance.
 - D) resonance.
 - E) sigmatism.

50. One of the major thematic concerns of Shakespeare's "[Devouring time, blunt thou the lion's paws]" is that
- A) beauty is not limited to women.
 - B) death comes to everything.
 - C) poetry will triumph over mortality.
 - D) poets have a tendency to talk to concepts.
 - E) time ravages the tiger's jaws.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-55 refer to Viraji Ogodapola's

Pipe Dreams

A dizain from down the alleys

Wayward thoughts and pungent smells soaking wet
 Sticking grunge, atop, under 'n inside sacks
 Housing hopeful tomorrows not yet met
 Pelleting sun in bouts past callous cracks 4
 The day's sighs of life on coarse measured tracks
 Ponder that rhyme and reason in spirits
 Obscured vision for the profound critics
 A song of the peripherals sans base 8
 Out of tune, to the rhyme of versed lyrics
 Symphony in silence, en route to ace

51. The particular absence of meter characterizing Viraji Ogodapola's "Pipe Dreams," points to the poet's writing in
- A) blank verse.
 - B) free verse.
 - C) nonsense verse.
 - D) projective verse.
 - E) syllabic verse.
52. The repetition of sibilant sounds in lines 4 and 5 especially is known as
- A) assonance.
 - B) consonance.
 - C) heteroglossia.
 - D) resonance.
 - E) sigmatism.
53. The imagery dominating the first two lines is both
- A) auditory and olfactory.
 - B) gustatory and visual.
 - C) kinesthetic and visual.
 - D) olfactory and tactile.
 - E) visual and tactile.

54. The particular absence of meter characterizing every line and which is especially obvious in the second line is achieved in the poem's second line through
- A) caesura.
 - B) elision.
 - C) enjambment.
 - D) hiatus.
 - E) metathesis.

55. Line 5's expressive *sighs* is an example of (a)
- A) ambiguity.
 - B) hieronymy.
 - C) litotes.
 - D) neologism.
 - E) onomatopoeia.

Items 56-59 refer to William Butler Yeats's

All Things Can Tempt Me

All things can tempt me from this craft of verse:
 One time it was a woman's face, or worse—
 The seeming needs of my fool-driven land;
 Now nothing but comes readier to the hand
 Than this accustomed toil. When I was young, 5
 I had not given a penny for a song
 Did not the poet Sing it with such airs
 That one believed he had a sword upstairs;
 Yet would be now, could I but have my wish,
 Colder and dumber and deafer than a fish. 10

56. The overarching metrical pattern of Yeats's poem is
- A) iambic pentameter.
 - B) iambic tetrameter.
 - C) trochaic pentameter.
 - D) spondaic tetrameter
 - E) trochaic tetrameter.
57. The use of more conjunctions than normal in line 10 is
- A) polyhyphenation.
 - B) polysyndeton.
 - C) sprung rhythm.
 - D) stichomythia.
 - E) synecdoche.
58. The poetic foot defining the final line's tone is the
- A) anapestic foot.
 - B) dactylic foot.
 - C) pyrrhic foot.
 - D) spondaic foot.
 - E) trochaic foot.

59. The subject matter of Yeats's confession—that distractions abound, and have abounded since his youth—is the deep personal calling to
- A) fall in love with a woman.
 - B) grow up to toil the soil.
 - C) move to a fool-driven land.
 - D) pay for all the songs he has heard.
 - E) write poetry.
62. The rhyming pairs "with their bells" and "citadels" (lines 2-3) and "stir and stress" and "silentness" (lines 6-7) are examples of
- A) compound rhyme.
 - B) heteromorous rhyme.
 - C) leonine rhyme.
 - D) pararhyme.
 - E) rhyme royal.

Items 60-65 refer to Thomas Hardy's

On the Belgian Expatriation *

October 18, 1914

I dreamt that people from the Land of Chimes*
Arrived one autumn morning with their bells,
To hoist them on the towers and citadels
Of my own country,* that the musical rhymes 4

Rung by them into space at meted times
Amid the market's daily stir and stress,
And the night's empty star-lit silentness,
Might solace souls of this and kindred climes. 8

Then I awoke; and lo, before me stood
The visioned ones, but pale and full of fear;
From Bruges they came, and Antwerp, and Ostend,

No carillons* in their train.* Foes of mad mood 12
Had shattered these to shards amid the gear
Of ravaged roof, and smouldering gable-end.

* a euphemism
* Belgium
* England
* bells
* convoy

60. The form of Thomas Hardy's "On the Belgian Expatriation" is the
- A) Belgian sonnet.
 - B) English sonnet.
 - C) Italian sonnet.
 - D) Miltonic sonnet.
 - E) Spenserian sonnet.
61. The sonnet's temporal volta occurs at the beginning of
- A) line 6.
 - B) line 9.
 - C) line 10.
 - D) line 12.
 - E) line 13.
63. The two quatrains that constitute the sonnet's octave are characterized by an *abba* rhyme scheme; these *abba* quatrains are
- A) ballad stanzas.
 - B) *In Memoriam* stanzas.
 - C) Poulter measures.
 - D) Pushkin stanzas.
 - E) Sapphic stanzas.
64. The continuation of sense and grammatical construction from one line to the next as occurs throughout Hardy's sonnet follows Hardy's use of
- A) end-stop lines.
 - B) fused lines.
 - C) run-on lines.
 - D) transliteration.
 - E) truncation.
65. The dominate imagery of the octave shifts to a different dominate imagery in the sestet; the shift is
- A) from auditory to visual.
 - B) from gustatory to visual.
 - C) from kinesthetic to tactile.
 - D) from tactile to kinesthetic.
 - E) from visual to auditory.

Required Tie-Breaking Essay

on next page

Required Tie-Breaking Essay

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook's* notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read William Shakespeare's "[Alack, what poverty my muse brings forth]," and, with special attention to the several comparisons that the speaker offers, analyze his argument that he does not have what it takes as an inspired poet to fully praise the beauty of the person whom he is addressing in Sonnet 103.

[Alack, what poverty my muse brings forth]

Alack, what poverty my muse brings forth, That, having such a scope to show her pride, The argument all bare is of more worth Than when it hath my added praise beside.	4
O, blame me not if I no more can write! Look in your glass, and there appears a face That overgoes my blunt invention quite, Dulling my lines and doing me disgrace.	8
Were it not sinful, then, striving to mend, To mar the subject that before was well? For to no other pass my verses tend Than of your graces and your gifts to tell.	12
And more, much more, than in my verse can sit Your own glass shows you when you look in it.	

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**UIL Literary Criticism
District • 2026**

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1.	D	482
2.	C	357
3.	A	24
4.	B	608
5.	A	72
6.	E	508
7.	C	173
8.	A	555
9.	C	210
10.	A	77
11.	E	506
12.	E	313
13.	B	70
14.	C	166
15.	D	246
16.	C	344
17.	E	464
18.	D	582
19.	D	605
20.	C	357
21.	D	300
22.	E	450
23.	A	176
24.	A	
25.	B	249
26.	C	219
27.	A	585
28.	B	294
29.	D	228
30.	D	603

31.	D
32.	E
33.	B
34.	D
35.	A
36.	C
37.	B
38.	C
39.	A
40.	E
41.	D
42.	E
43.	A
44.	D
45.	D
46.	E
47.	C
48.	B
49.	A
50.	C
51.	E
52.	E
53.	D
54.	B
55.	E
56.	A
57.	B
58.	B
59.	E
60.	C
61.	B
62.	B
63.	B
64.	C
65.	A

13 **FOLD**
25 along the **three**
67 longitudinal
97 lines for ease
in grading. ➔

89 **Please** note that the objective
174 scores should not be altered to
6 reflect the breaking of any ties.
Simply adjust ranking.

245
232 The thirty items in Part 1
259 are worth one point each.
254 The twenty items in Part 2
37 are worth two points each.
405 The fifteen items in Part 3
372 are worth two points each.

470 **DO NOT**
237 mark (cross out)
257 actual **LETTER** answer;
43 mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

465

167 Page numbers refer
337 to the *Handbook 12e*,

W. W. Norton
The Iceman Cometh,

HarperPerennial
To Kill a Mockingbird,
and

Folger Library
Shakespeare's Sonnets, Poems

260

232

253 *#63 has no correct answer choice
425 and should be disregarded.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

- the degree to which the instructions have been followed,
- the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,
- the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and
- the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's Sonnet 103

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used by the contestant in an analysis that focuses on the several comparisons that the speaker offers while arguing that he does not have what it takes as an inspired poet to fully praise the beauty of the person whom he is addressing in Shakespeare's Sonnet 103 "[Alack, what poverty my muse brings forth]"—however the concept *muse* is to be understood, include

alliteration,	muse,
apostrophe,	ploce,
assonance,	rhyme scheme,
diction,	sigmatism,
iambic pentameter,	simile,
imagination,	tone, and
inversion,	volta.

NB: The contestant does **not** have to recognize that Shakespeare's muse, his invention, is, indeed, his own imagination. Some younger LitCritters might not recognize the three principal comparisons as similes. This non-recognition should not undercut the strength of the contestant's analysis.

Any well-organized analysis that supports its thesis with more than a couple of supporting instances of comparisons suffices to answer the prompt.

The young writer should recognize that the argument that the speaker is making: that his imagination, his muse, fails to adequately address the beauty that he has encountered turns on similes, as well as additional comparisons. The similes are line 4's "Than when [my argument] hath"; line 12's "Than of [his muse's] graces"; and line 13's "than in my verse can."

Additionally, the speaker's consternation, "Alack, what poverty [. . .] having such a scope" (lines 1-2), suggests a comparison. Line 5's "if I no more can write!" declares a **now** against a comparison of a **before**. Line 7's "That overgoes my blunt invention" is an embedded comparison, as is line 9's "striving to mend," which is purposely followed by "To mar [. . .] that before was well" (line 10).

The LitCritic might recognize the emphasis in line 13's ploce "more, much more" as a form of comparison.*

Implicit in the volta—almost lost in the line's inversion—is a conditional (note, please, the subjunctive mood), which is an explicit comparison in the hypothetical: "Were it not sinful, **then**, striving to mend]" (line 9).

*The *Handbook* fails to address the simple repetition of a word for emphasis as ploce—thus never tested in LC.